

SIPHA DAS



The patriarch who has presided over the House of Elders for the last five years as a sort of modern-day Bhishma Pitamah is now campaigning for the 'conscience vote'. As a slogan, it works. After all, this is what defeated the Congress's official candidate Sanjiva Reddy in 1969 when Indira Gandhi asked for a 'conscience vote' in favour of her nominee, V.V. Giri. Moreover, unlike the UPA candidate, the *dhoti*-clad, tobacco-chewing Shekhawat has lived the past half century in public glare. He has been an elected member of the legislature since 1952 except for a brief spell of two years. His colleagues don't have to hit a search engine to figure out his politics. And it doesn't always conform to type. When most Rajput leaders supported Roop Kanwar's sati in 1987, he took to the streets denouncing it in the strongest political terms. He has advocated stern action against rapists but also faced flak from women activists when he protected innocents indicted in false rape cases. He is one of the few Rajput leaders to have campaigned actively for widow remarriage.

He may be able to sway the masses but he could do little to change the conservative mindset of his own family. Despite his pleas, his wife refused to let him send their grand-daughter Moomal to London for higher studies. "Family pressures can be unbearable at times," he

THE CHALLENGE: The NDA is hoping Shekhawat's cross-party appeal will transcend the saffron divide

muttered somewhat ruefully. So you win some and lose some. Shekhawat is too seasoned a player to let little defeats bog him down. For most of his stint as chief minister and as vice-president, he has had to deal with a Congress government in power at the Centre. When he was chief minister, his partymen used to grumble that he was more considerate to the Opposition than to his own party. Shekhawat retorted that in politics there can be opposition, but there should be no enemies.

At six feet tall, Shekhawat's larger-than-life persona is the icing on one of the most colourful political campaigns in presidential history. Whether he wins the presidential sweepstakes or not, his term as vice-president is coming to an end. It is his off-the-cuff pithy comments that his colleagues say they will miss the most. During Question Hour, when some members claimed that leprosy was a communicable disease, Shekhawat commented that while leprosy was not, asking questions seemed to be a communicable disease. Unlike some "loudspeakers" in the Lok Sabha, he has never raised his voice in the house—one scathing look from under his bushy eyebrows usually does the trick. Wrestler-turned-politician Dara Singh once told him, "My wife often watches the proceedings of the House on TV and wonders at the way you control the House." Shekhawat smiled and said, "Maybe after watching TV she will learn to control you as well!"

Has Shekhawat been used by the BJP to fight a battle that is stacked against him? If anyone can win this fight, it is Shekhawat, say NDA leaders. The vice-president says he is confident. Not too long ago, Farooq Abdullah had wondered how the octogenarian always managed to look so red in the cheeks, and asked if he wore rouge. Shekhawat did not answer then. The grand old man at the peak of his fighting spirit is not giving out any answers even now.



MANDAR DEODHAR

"When Kalam was in the race, Shekhawat withdrew. Now he is in. What kind of *saudebaazi* (trading) is this?"

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SHIV SENA CHIEF